12

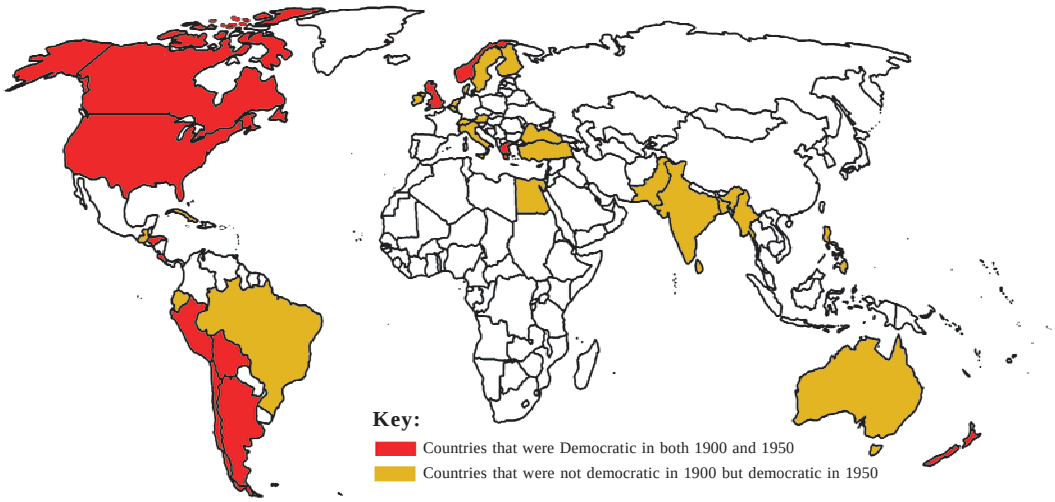
The Main Features of democracy

After 1950 many countries liberated from colonialism began establishing democratic governments. In the 1980s and 1990s, the decline of the communist regimes saw the further spread of democratic rule. After 2010, countries like Libya and Myanmar raised their voice against dictatorship and also opted for the democratic system.

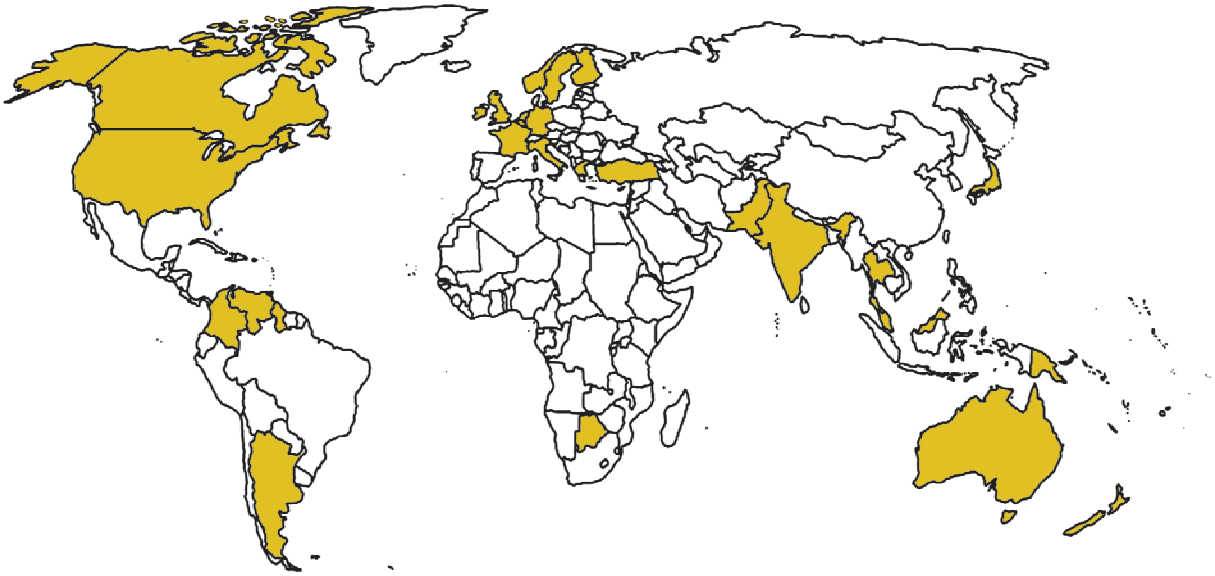
Dictatorship is a term used to describe the rule of a person who establishes total dominion over a country. The dictator takes control of all organs of government. Col Gaddafi and Gen Ne Win are examples of dictators. Such individuals gain the support of their army. They suppress all political opposition to establish single party rule. Dictators centralize all political power in their hands. They rule according to their will, enacting laws that suit their requirements. Justice is dispensed in accordance with the decisions of their government. Democracy is the opposite of dictatorship as a system of governance.

Democracy

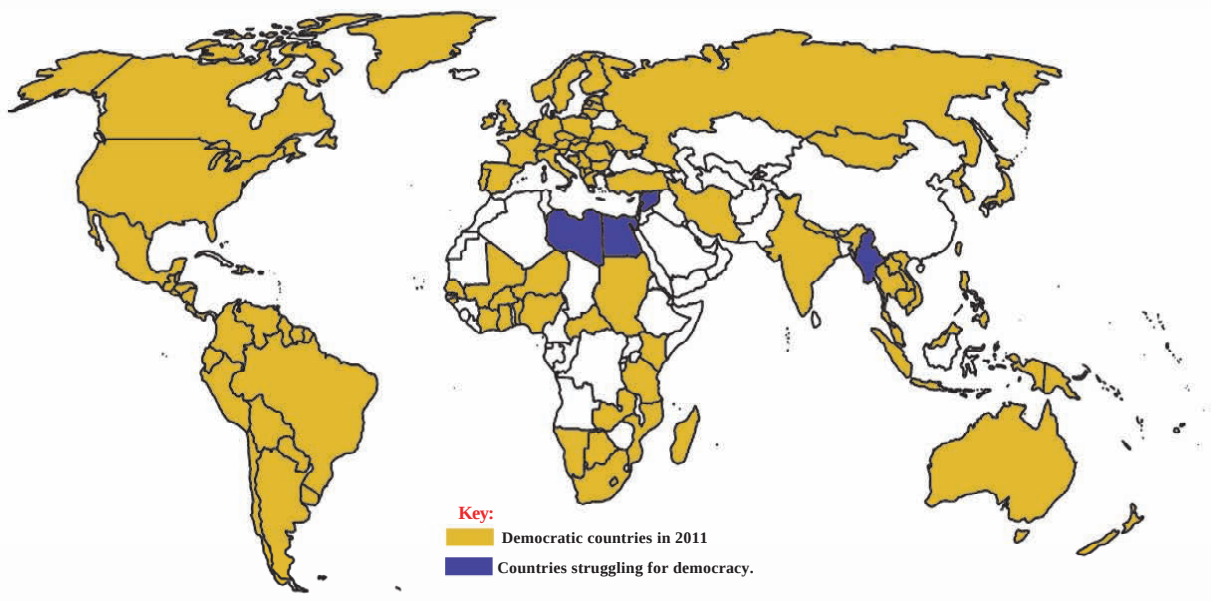
We learnt about the evolution of democracy in Europe and its spread across the world in the history chapters. The political developments during the 18th and 19th centuries led to the decline in power of the monarchies in Europe. The French Revolution inspired democratic struggles in many parts of Europe In France itself, democracy was established after many ups and downs at the end of the 19th century. The struggles for democratic governance in the 19th century were based on the principles of political freedom, equality and justice.



Map 12.1: Democratic countries between 1900 and 1950



Map 12.2: Democratic countries between 1950 and 1975



Map 12.3 Democratic countries between 1975 and 2000

Study the maps given above to analyse the spread of democracy across the world. Take the help of your teacher.

In Map 12.1, identify the countries that became democratic between 1900 and 1950.

In Maps 12.1 and 12.2, identify the countries that became democratic between 1950 and 1975.

In Maps 12.2 and 12.3, identify the European countries that became democratic between 1975 and 2000.

Identify the countries in South America that adopted democracy after 1975.

Make a list of the countries that had not adopted democracy even as late as 2000.

Which was the most important period for the spread of democracy? Study the maps to find the answer.

Three important points to remember from **the struggle for democracy in the two countries** we read about in the last lesson:

1. **The establishment of monarchy and Col Gaddafi's rule after Libya gained independence.**
2. **The establishment of military rule in Myanmar after the death of Aung San.**
3. **The struggle for democracy in Libya and Myanmar.**

Discuss the following with the help of your teacher:

What are the differences and similarities between the governments of these two countries? Why do we call these two governments as dictatorships?

What rights were the people of Libya and Myanmar deprived of in the absence of democracy?

If Gaddafi had respected and strengthened democratic institutions, what effect would it have had on the people of Libya?

In Libya and Myanmar, the people did not elect the military leaders who controlled the army. The military leaders seized power themselves. The people had no role to play in the decisions of their government. Governments that are elected by the people of a country are known as democratic governments. In a democratic government, people elect their representatives and these chosen representatives run the government. The people play an important role in choosing and changing the government.

The discussion above inevitably raises the following questions in one's mind:

1. **Who will be the ruler?**
2. **What kind of elections are called democratic?**
3. **Who elects the rulers?**
4. **What qualifications are needed to be elected as a ruler?**

We need to analyse the main features of democracy if we wish to find answers to these questions.

An Aaccountable Government

We saw that the ultimate decision-making power in Libya lay with the military ruler. He was not chosen by the people. The people were compelled to abide by the orders of the military junta. The junta was not accountable to anyone.

In a democratic country, the representatives chosen by the people and the legislative assembly are supreme. There are various ways in which elected governments are accountable to the people. A look at the government system in India will show us that the central and state governments are accountable to the people and their representatives in many ways.

In India, all members of the executive – like the prime minister, chief-minister, council of ministers and senior officials - are accountable to the parliament or the state legislative assemblies.

Elections After Fixed Intervals

All democratic governments are elected for a fixed period. Do you know how many years this fixed period is in India? A government can return to power only if it is re-elected by the people. Elections are

the time when the people experience and exercise their power in a democracy. By holding elections at fixed intervals, people retain control over the government. If people are not satisfied with the performance of their elected representatives, they can change the government through elections.

Free and Fair Elections

To hold free and fair elections, it is necessary that they are conducted by an independent body and all political parties are permitted to participate without any pre-conditions. India has a body called the Election Commission to conduct elections. The constitution bestows special powers on the Election Commission to conduct free and fair elections. A multi-party system is also necessary in a democracy to hold impartial elections. It gives people a range of alternatives to choose from.

Under which conditions can people change their government? Discuss in class.

Why are elections conducted after a fixed period of time?

Why is it necessary to have more than one political party in a democracy?

Universal Adult Franchise

We say that democracy is a government by the people. This means every adult in the country – whether male or female, rich or poor, of any religion or faith, or speaking any language – has the right to vote. This is political equality. Each vote has the same value. Whether rich or poor, literate or illiterate, every person's vote has equal value.

In the beginning, some countries limited the right to vote to only those people who owned property or paid taxes. After much struggle, the right to vote was gradually given to everybody. In India, universal adult franchise was accepted from the day the constitution was adopted. This means all people aged 18 years and above can cast their vote.

Should there be some conditions for universal adult franchise? Discuss in class.

What are your views on political equality?

In India, from which year was the electronic voting machine used in elections?

People's Participation in Democracy

In a democracy, people participate in the functioning of the government. Citizens play an active role in making and implementing laws. It is the people who inform the government of their problems and needs.

Before a policy is formulated, it is widely discussed among the people. There are many ways this is done to strengthen democracy. People write articles in the newspapers and present memorandums to the government about the proposed law or policy. They participate in discussions on television and on the internet. They hold seminars, workshops and meetings. They use many other methods to make their opinions on the law or policy known. There are many societies and committees to direct these discussions and interactions. The biggest enemy of democracy is the apathy of the people.

In what ways can you participate in a democracy? Discuss in class.

Do you think democracy can be successful without people's participation?



Figure 12.1: Women casting their vote in an election



Figure 12.2: Electronic voting machine (EVM)

The Rule of Law

A defining characteristic of a democracy is the rule of law. This means the government performs all its functions in accordance with the law and does not do anything which is against the law. The rule of law also means that all laws apply equally to all the citizens of a country. No individual is exempted from the law in any way. There are many instances when high-ranking officials and powerful leaders have had to face legal proceedings in the courts just like the common citizens.

Respect for the Law

In a democracy, we depend on institutions that function according to the constitution and the law. No one has the authority to perform an illegal act. Respecting this principle means respecting the law.

A democratic government cannot act arbitrarily just because it has been elected to power. It has to accept and function in accordance with some basic laws and rules of conduct. It is the duty of the government and the people to respect a free and independent judiciary.

List the incidents that have occurred around you that you feel have violated the law. Discuss your list in class with the help of your teacher.

Human Rights and Democracy

Human rights are those entitlements that are necessary for an individual to live with dignity and progress in life. People cannot realise their full potential without these rights. They are bestowed these rights in a democracy. In other words, the right to express one's opinions, right to question, debate and discuss, right to form associations and other human rights are what give democracy strength and legitimacy.

How will people's participation in a democracy be affected if they had no human rights?

Rights of Minorities

In most countries there are small populations of people of a certain race, religion, community, language, colour, region, sex or political thought. These small populations of people are called minorities. Most countries are ruled by people belonging to the majority community. Democracy doesn't mean uniformity.

It accepts diversity in society. So respecting the opinion of the minorities is an integral part of democratic values. Hence, minorities are guaranteed certain rights by the constitution.

In any region, who are defined as minorities? Explain with an example.

If minorities do not have the same rights as the majority, how will they be affected?

Why is it important to accept diversity in a democracy?

Democracy and Inclusiveness

In a democracy, the government is formed on the basis of the majority. Even if there are differing and dissenting views, the decision taken on the basis of the majority view is accepted. But such decisions are not always inclusive. The minorities often feel a sense of alienation. A democracy needs to foster inclusive processes to ensure the participation of the minorities. They should not feel left out.

Let us try to understand this with an example. Belgium is a small country in Europe. Its society is divided into the following ethnic and language groups: 59% speak Dutch, 40% speak French and a few speak German. They mostly live in distinct and separate regions. But 80% of the people speak French in the capital Brussels and 20% speak Dutch. The three communities have always been in a situation of confrontation. This was especially true of Brussels where the Dutch speakers are in a minority. In such a situation, Belgium took the following special measures to ensure an inclusive society:

The constitution has a clear provision that there must be equal representation of Dutch and French-speaking ministers in the central government. Important laws can only be passed if they have the support of the majority of parliamentarians belonging to both language groups. In this way, no community can make a one-sided decision in its favour.

- **The constitution delegates many powers to the regional governments. So the regional governments cannot be regulated by the central government in these matters.**
- **Brussels has a separate government with equal representation of both communities. The French-speaking people in Brussels have accepted this proposal for equal representation because the Dutch-speaking people have accepted equal representation in the central government.**

This shows how sensibly the people of Belgium have included people speaking different languages in the functioning of the government.

What does inclusion mean? Explain with an example.

Why is inclusion of different communities necessary?

What can we do to improve democracy? Discuss in class.

List the activities, based on democratic values, you would undertake if you were appointed as *sarpanch* or municipal commissioner.

What we learnt in this chapter

Arguments for and against democracy

For Democracy:	Against Democracy:
Democracy is a government of the people. Hence, elections are conducted periodically. It is important for all governments in a democracy to function according to the constitution.	The representatives in a democracy keep changing. This leads to instability.
Widespread participation of the people brings greater transparency examples of ethical functioning. Different views and opinions are accommodated.	Democracy is only about political battles and power play. There is no room for ethical functioning.
Since this system of governance depends on the participation of greater numbers of people, it takes more time to function. But this helps to bring out the merits/demerits of issues, thereby making it possible to reach better decisions.	Decision-making is delayed in a democracy because issues have to be discussed and debated by the masses.
Electoral reforms are helping to reduce the expense of government functioning. Democracy is constantly progressing. This process ensures the maximum protection of citizens' rights. As democracy is strengthened, its deficiencies are also gradually eliminated.	Electoral battles are important and expensive so there is scope for corruption.

Are there other merits and demerits in a democracy? Discuss in class and add to the above list.

We have tried to explain the concepts of democracy and dictatorship. We saw how, in a dictatorship, military leaders like Libya's Col Gaddafi and Myanmar's Gen Ne Win tried to establish one-party, one-leader rule and the methods they used to control all facets of government to strengthen their rule.

Democracy is the opposite of dictatorship. It visualizes a government of people's representatives in which an attempt is made to widen the scope of people's participation in all functions of the government. A dictatorship believes in the strength of a single party and a single leader. A one-leader government progresses towards authoritarian rule and distances itself from the people. Col Gaddafi is an example. A democracy, on the other hand, believes in the collective ability of the people to make a decision and has faith that the people can make the right decision collectively.

In a dictatorship, there is no place for people's rights, self-respect and dignity, whereas a democracy cannot function without citizens' rights.

In a dictatorship, the media and people's personal freedom depend on the whims of the government, whereas in democratic governance, an independent communication media plays an important role in political discourse. A democracy cannot function without personal freedoms.

EXERCISES

1. Choose the correct word and fill in the blanks:

(Democratic dignity mistakes system of government accountable)

A ……..…..…….....…… form of government is better than other forms because this government is more…….....…….....…..Democratic citizens have …….....……. Democracy has scope to reform and correct its ……..……..... This is why democracy is considered the best ……..……

2. Choose the best option:

1. Democracy is rule by:
   a) a king
   b) the people
   c) the army
   d) feudal forces
2. Who had the ultimate decision-making power in Libya?
   a) the people
   b) the representatives chosen by the people
   c) the military junta
   d) the legislators
3. What form of government does India have?
   a) dictatorship
   b) monarchy
   c) military junta
   d) democracy

3. Answer the following:

1. What is meant by dictatorship?
2. Who was the military junta in Libya and Myanmar accountable to?
3. What do you understand by people's participation in democracy?
4. Why cannot a government democratically elected by the people act in an arbitrary manner?
5. What are the special characteristics of a democracy?
6. Does a democracy have more positive or negative qualities? Discuss in class and make a list.
7. What are the arrangements needed to hold free and fair elections? Make a list of your suggestions.

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